



Leopard 1

The German Leopard, in all its many forms, is undoubtedly one of the most successful postwar tank designs. When the West German Army was re-formed in 1955, it was initially equipped with American tanks, but two years later a Franco-German tank development program began. However, this partnership ended in 1962, and France went its own way to build the rival AMX-30 design.

GERMANY CONTINUED the wartime practice of ordering prototypes from different companies (or, in this case, groups of companies) and then selecting the best model. In 1963, Krauss-Maffei of Munich was awarded the contract for the new Standard Panzer, the tank that became known as Leopard 1. In contrast to late-World War II German tank design, the Leopard emphasized mobility over protection. However, in terms of firepower, the Germans selected the best weapon available at that time—the British 105 mm L7 gun, as used in the Centurion (see pp.142–45). Although it began life as a relatively simple tank, new technologies, increased armor protection, and individual countries’ requirements led to the Leopard developing many subvariants. This version is the Leopard 1A1A2, which has a gun stabilization system, additional layers of armor around the turret, and improved gunsights and observation equipment.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	Leopard 1A1A2
Date	1965
Origin	West Germany
Production	6,486
Engine	MTU MB838 10-cylinder multifuel, 830 hp
Weight	46.7 tons (42.4 tonnes)
Main armament	105 mm L7A3
Secondary armament	2 x 7.62 mm MG3
Crew	4
Armor thickness	0.39-2.76 in (10-70 mm)

A technical diagram showing the internal layout of the Leopard 1A1A2 tank's turret and hull. The diagram is labeled with the positions of the crew members: Loader (at the rear of the turret), Engine (in the hull), Driver (in the hull), Commander (in the turret), and Gunner (in the turret). The diagram illustrates the spatial arrangement and the flow of information and ammunition between these roles.